

**WAR & REMEMBRANCE: JAPANESE-AMERICAN FAMILY STRUGGLES WITH PATRIOTISM AFTER
ARKANSAS INTERNMENT**

SPECIAL TO THE DEMOCRAT-GAZETTE - RICHARD YADA

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THIS ARTICLE HAS TWO PARTS

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Bob (from left), Richard, Sam, Haruye, Sarah, and Barbara Yada visit the Otorii Gate in Miyajima Township, Japan, during a family trip in the 1970s or '80s.

This article is special to me as I met Sam Yada, Richard's father when they lived in North Little Rock, Arkansas sometime during the 80's I think. I was their mailman for several years during this time frame and I remember visiting with Sam while delivering the mail to their home many times. I recently reached out to try and make contact with Richard (who wrote this article) on his Facebook page but was unsuccessful. John Chamberlin, Jun 8, 2024

PLEASE NOTE BEFORE READING THIS ARTICLE: This is a supplement to Article 376. Article # 376 was about the establishment of the camps and living in them. This article covers one of the families that lived in the camps and their activities after the War. As stated above, I met and visited with the father of the family concerned. I hope you enjoy this article. The father is Sam Yada, his wife Haruye Masada-Yada, and his sons, Bob and Richard who wrote this article in 2018

PART ONE

Richard Yada's first impressions of the world were formed behind a barbed-wire fence where guards carried rifles on their shoulders.

Nearly 8,000 Japanese-Americans were taken from their homes during World War II and imprisoned in barracks in the Rohwer War Relocation Center for the duration of the war. Another camp in Jerome held about the same number.

Richard, who was born at Rohwer, his parents, his aunt, and his brother, Bob, were held at the camp. ***The Yadas were the only family to stay in Arkansas after the war ended.***

The family would eventually build a successful greenhouse business after years of sharecropping.

Richard and Bob went on to graduate from college, and both served in the military for the same country that had once made them prisoners.

Attempts to keep the memories of what happened at the camps from fading are ongoing in McGehee, a town near Rohwer and Jerome, and in Little Rock at the Butler Center for Arkansas Studies, which started a two-year series of exhibitions about the camps in 2017.

A new exhibit focused on student life opened earlier this month. Richard, who was only in the camp for the first two years of his life, says most of his knowledge of what happened, and why, has been gathered through bits and pieces of information over the years.

"They never had to say, 'Let's sit down and talk about what happened in the camp,'" the Little Rock resident says of his parents. "We never did that."

The Arkansas camps were two out of 10 across the United States that held more than 120,000 Japanese-Americans during the war. Many were American citizens, ***and none were ever convicted of espionage or treason.***

By Dec. 7, 1941 -- the date Japan bombed Pearl Harbor -- Richard's family had been in the United States for generations. They were scattered; some lived in Hawaii, some in California. Some were still in Japan.

In the weeks and days leading up to the bombing of Pearl Harbor, seemingly insignificant decisions shaped lives -- determining whether a teenager lived or died, displacing an entire family branch, leaving another nearly unscathed.

NISEI

At the time, second-generation Japanese-Americans referred to themselves as "nisei." They operated under values of honor and obedience to authority, learned from their parents. One common Japanese phrase used among the nisei and their parents was translated: "It can't be helped."

Richard's mother, Haruye Masada-Yada, was a member of the Nisei. Her father came to the United States from Japan. Her mother came later as a "picture bride," Haruye, who was born in the United States, said years later during an interview with a representative from the Japanese American National Museum in Los Angeles. ***Haruye died in 2014 at age 99;*** the interview with the museum is the last remaining record of her story.

Her parents lived in California, although they sent their children back to Japan for school. It was hard for their kids to get a good education in the United States because the parents moved often, looking for seasonal work and traveling to keep up as different fruits ripened.

When she came back to the States as a teenager, Haruye barely spoke English but tried to attend high school.

"I went, about three years only," she said. "I was placed with small children, so I became very frustrated and resentful being in that situation."

Her father got sick with what seemed to be stomach cancer, and the family moved back to Japan briefly when Haruye was a teenager.

The decision to come back to the United States after a year of treatment was not an easy one -- her father was the oldest male in his family and was expected to stay and carry on the family name in his own country.

He said it was impossible to make a living in Japan, and he avoided going back after the treatment because he would have been pressured to stay, Haruye said.

"No matter what, need to go back to America," Haruye says in a transcript of the interview.

When she was 21, relatives arranged for her to marry Sam Yada, who was about 10 years older.

They met twice before their wedding in 1936.

"My aunt kept telling me that he was a good person, a very kind person, a persevering and honest worker," she said. Six decades later, when she heard he had died just before his 86th birthday, Haruye would sprint upstairs to get to him because the elevator was too slow.

Their oldest son, Bob, was born in 1937 and doesn't remember much of his experience living in California outside of playing in the dirt while his mother worked in the celery fields. In between shifts at the field, she cooked for people living in the workers' commune. Customers could buy meals for 50 cents each.

Sam was a mechanic, and when news of the war broke, the couple talked about moving their small family somewhere safer -- maybe Nebraska -- but decided against it; the change would have been too much stress and cost too much. Besides, Haruye liked raising her children in a simple farm life.

'AGAINST ESPIONAGE AND SABOTAGE'

"According to the provisions of Civilian Exclusion Order No. 34 this Headquarters, dated May 3, 1942, all persons of Japanese ancestry, both alien and non-alien will be evacuated ... "

-- Orders from the U.S. Army

After President Franklin D. Roosevelt signed Executive Order 9066 in 1942, investigations began. Japanese-American leaders were removed from their positions and put in war camps. Language schools closed. Business operations were seized.

Although the act itself didn't specify Japanese-Americans, they were targeted with much higher frequency than German-Americans or Italian-Americans because they "wore the faces of the enemy."

Families were confused -- why was the FBI investigating American citizens? What were they looking for? Haruye's response was to get rid of any evidence. She didn't want the government to know she had been educated in Japan.

They built a fire in the front yard and tossed in personal effects, photos, and signs of their heritage, says Bob Yada, Richard's older brother.

"You didn't know what the consequences were if the FBI found it," he says. Bob is now retired and lives in Fort Smith.

Soon after, the relocations started. Japanese-Americans tried handing off their property to friends and neighbors. One man recounted in information from the World War II Japanese American Internment Museum in McGehee that his father tried to hand off the family dog to a friend for safekeeping until he returned. ***The man accepted care of the pet and promptly shot it.***

Most of these moves happened from the West Coast to middle America where any traitorous prisoners would have a harder time communicating with the Japanese government. However, in Hawaii, where Japanese fighters dropped bombs, and about a third of the population was Japanese, most families remained free, according to information from the museum in McGehee.

Estimates at the time showed that Hawaii's economy would have collapsed if all the Japanese-Americans had been pulled out of the workforce. Very few were interned at a camp; Sam's family was not.

Before the war started, Sam's teenage sister, Sadami Hamamoto, had traveled from Hawaii to stay with the family. She planned to stay for a year, help out on the farm, and then go back to finish school.

If she had stayed, she would have been able to graduate with her friends on the island. Instead, ***she graduated on a racetrack at a prison camp.***

She, along with her brother, sister-in-law, and nephew, was rounded up and taken to horse stables in Stockton, Calif., while the barracks in Arkansas were being prepared for their arrival.

"They had built some temporary barracks, and we got to stay in the barracks, ***but some of them had to stay in the horse stalls," Bob says.***

When the housing in Arkansas was ready, the Yada family was loaded onto a steam-engine train for the four-day trip. Each family was allotted one bench to sit and sleep on.

"There was a conductor and he was joking with me," Bob says. "I was scared to death to ride on the train but when we got to our destination in Rohwer, he gave me a piece of Dentyne chewing gum. The MPs had a formation around the area so we wouldn't escape," Bob says. "I don't know where we would escape to."

IMPRISONED

The road into Rohwer was lined with long, black, wooden buildings filled with families trying to make sense of things. A guard tower at the front of the camp overlooked the structures built on the low-lying farmland.

A pile of scrap wood was quickly snatched up to be made into furniture. ***Sam made boxes for his family to store clothes and a crib for the baby they were expecting -- Richard.***

The internees flooding Rohwer and Jerome made the small Delta towns the fifth and sixth largest cities in the state.

The Yadas, like the others held at the camp, ***lived in one room with a potbelly stove, a single light bulb hanging from the ceiling, and three Army cots lining the walls. The space was about 15 by 20 feet, Richard says.***

Adults were allowed to work -- for the lowest wage an Army private could make at the time, about \$17 a month -- to buy trinkets and candy from the commissary. Sam worked as a lumberjack and in the kitchens. Haruye learned to sew in an adult class while caring for her sons.

Families rarely ate together; children chose to eat in the dining hall with their friends, and usually only saw their parents at night.

This caused families to fracture in ways that proved difficult to repair, former internees say in the PBS documentary.

Bob ate with his friends and spent the days playing with them. He was still too young for school, and there were no chores to do in the camp.

"We had blow-gun fights and would sling clay balls at each other," he says. "We would roll up the clay ball, put it on the end of the stick, and just sling it."

Each internee was given a name tag to wear; it was required when they left the confines of their barracks. Bob said "Robert," which was not his birth name, but it stuck and he had his name changed from Bob to Robert when he became a teenager.

Richard was born in 1943, about a year after the camp opened. An Army ambulance transported Haruye to a military hospital in the camp.

It was hard to find ways to celebrate big life events and holidays in the camps, but Bob says his mother tried. For his fifth birthday, she cooked a meal for just the family and took his picture.

One year on Christmas Eve, he asked his father if Santa Claus could bring him a new bicycle. Sam told his son that a bicycle wouldn't fit down the chimney, but that he could ask for something else. Bob decided on a Boy Scout knife, which was waiting for him the next morning.

"That was one of my most pleasant memories of incarceration," Bob says. "I never asked him how he got it."

Bob went to school at the camp through the second grade, but Richard was not old enough.

Most of his memories of being imprisoned are blurry -- sitting on the grass next to his mother, the soldiers with their rifles, watching older kids play in the creek. He didn't learn to speak English until after his family left the camp.

"When we got out of the camp and moved to Scott, I figured everybody else speaks English, so I'd better pick that up myself," Richard says. "I just blocked it [Japanese] off, and I wish I had some knowledge of that. It left."

As the war wound down, internees were allowed to leave to work in the interior of the United States. Richard and Bob's aunt got a job as a nanny in Ohio and left before the rest of the family.

Before leaving the camp, adults were required to fill out a loyalty questionnaire. It was designed to divide the Japanese-Americans into "**loyal**" or "**disloyal**" categories. Those in the disloyal category would be required to go to a higher security camp, and yet many were labeled disloyal, which researchers say was likely a response to being imprisoned without cause or trial, according to the *Densho Encyclopedia*, which chronicles the story of the Japanese-Americans during WWII.

Question 27 asked if men would be willing to serve in the draft. Question 28 asked if individuals would forswear any allegiance to the Emperor of Japan.

Sam and Haruye didn't feel allegiance to either country and answered "no" to both. Several men interned at Rohwer and Jerome served in the war, fighting in Europe. "We were placed in camps, and how could they ask us such questions, that's what he [Sam] said," Haruye told the museum interviewer.

The Yada family was one of the last to leave Rohwer and one of the few who didn't go far.

PART TWO

CONFINED, CONFOUNDED: FAMILY AMONG THOUSANDS OF JAPANESE-AMERICANS HELD IN TWO ARKANSAS PRISON CAMPS IN WW2

Until he learned that his cousins had died when an atomic bomb demolished Hiroshima in 1945, Richard Yada didn't think twice about joining the U.S. military.

He and his older brother, Bob, both served during the Vietnam War, despite spending the early years of their childhood imprisoned at Rohwer War Relocation Center in Arkansas.

More than 120,000 Japanese Americans were taken from their homes and sequestered during World War II in 10 camps across the country, including two in the Arkansas Delta.

His was the only Japanese-American family to settle in the Natural State after being kept behind gates for years. A few other families chose to stay awhile and took up sharecropping along with the Yadas; none of them remained long-term.

In the years that followed imprisonment, Japanese-American families fought to recover. They had lost their homes, businesses and many belongings. Families were no longer tightly knit. Their place in society going forward was unsure.

"To undo a mistake is always harder than not to create one originally, but we seldom have the foresight." Eleanor Roosevelt

Richard and Bob's mother, Haruye Masada-Yada, who died in 2014, was born in the United States but spent part of her childhood in Japan. And when she was a teenager, her father moved the whole family back to Japan for a year while he underwent treatment for what they thought was stomach cancer

OBITUARY OF HARUYE MASADA – YADA

To view: Copy and paste the below link into your browser

<https://www.arkansasonline.com/news/2014/sep/14/haruye-masada-yada-20140914/>

His decision to return to the United States, although it upset extended family who wanted his support, probably saved Haruye's life. In a 2003 interview she gave to the Japanese American National Museum, she remembered how she got married in California and so didn't return to Japan when her parents went back again.

Although she wasn't free during the war, being interned at Rohwer, ***she also was not with her cousins when "Little Boy" exploded over Hiroshima.***

The morning of Aug. 6, 1945, a warning came through the city that there would be an air raid -- maybe about three small planes would drop a few bombs. Haruye's cousins loaded up on buses to drive away from the danger zone.

What came instead was an atomic bomb, a mushroom of smoke billowing in the sky. The first sitting president to visit Hiroshima, Barack Obama, in 2016 called it the day "death fell from the sky and the world was changed." Haruye's cousins and uncle were killed, she said in the interview.

One teenage cousin's body was found. The details of its condition from family members who tried to pick it up out of rubble haunt Richard.

But her parents were safe. Their savior was a hill near their house. Haruye told interviewers that the "shadow of the mountain" protected them from the blast

"The justice those days was interesting," Haruye said. "The idea of dropping the atom bomb on Japan.

The second bomb, dropped five days later on Nagasaki, brought the estimated death toll up from about 150,000 to 225,000. These estimates are conservative; bodies and documents were unrecognizable, according to a report from the University of California at Los Angeles. At the time of the bombings, **a dozen American prisoners of war were being held in Hiroshima. They also died.**

When the camps closed, former internees **were not allowed to own land in Arkansas.** The governor at the time, Homer Adkins, backed the law that kept anyone of Japanese descent from owning land. Adkins was a known member of the Ku Klux Klan, although he later said he only joined to gain political support.

"He [Adkins] said you can build those camps here, but once the war is over these people have got to leave," Richard Yada said. "They cannot go to school here. They cannot buy land here. They've just got to leave. Most of them did. "Several families, including the Yadas, took up sharecropping so they could get around the law and stay in Arkansas.

Sam Yada, Richard and Bob's father, had heard from friends back in California that life as an Asian-American was bleak in the West; property had been stolen, homes were being shot at and racism was rampant. **He decided to keep his family in Arkansas.**

They started sharecropping in Scott in 1945, along with several other families who had left Rohwer. Sam drove a truck for the group so his family could make a little bit of extra money. "They shared the tractors: 'It's your turn to use the tractor, my turn to use the mule,'" Richard said.

"They brought all the produce in together. "From their one, 15-by-20-foot room in the camp, the family had upgraded to a house with three rooms and running water for a bathtub.

The wooden floor had holes in it, and the chickens would run underneath. Richard entertained himself by finding pieces of corn or small sticks to drop through the holes onto the chickens' heads.

"It was not very well built," he said. "**The wallpaper was old newspapers,** so when the wind blew you could see it go in and out."

Bob was old enough to drive, so he helped out on the farm. He remembers it as the hardest work he has ever done.

Both boys were going to school, and Virginia Alexander, the woman who owned the land the Japanese-American families were farming, fought for them to go to the white school.

"That was a life-changing event for me **because the black schools weren't getting any funding for their education,**" Richard said. "All the white schools were getting all the money for education and the black schools weren't getting their equal share of education money, so [switching schools] made a big difference for me."

Bob graduated from Little Rock Central High School in 1955, just two years before the school desegregated.

It was close to the same time when the family moved onto their farm, near North Little Rock. They began their greenhouse business there, planting tomatoes.

After two decades of building that business up, Sam and Haruye had to move again when Interstate 440 was being built and scheduled to go right through their living room.

The other families who started sharecropping with the Yadas moved off one by one, putting distance between themselves and the place where they had been prisoners until only the Yada family was left.

Bob was going to junior college and stayed home to help out with the greenhouses.

He started at the University of Arkansas, Fayetteville, but didn't finish because he joined the Army. He was a part of a medical team that got called up during the Berlin Crisis in 1961. He finished school later, after the crisis, and worked for the Army at Fort Chaffee for most of his career.

He also got a call in 1975 when Vietnamese refugees came to Fort Smith after the fall of Saigon

"I was in bed," Bob said in an interview with a representative from The Fort Smith Historical Society. "And early in the morning, I got a call from my boss."

He and his crew worked to get the fort ready for buses full of Vietnamese people to arrive; he said they were treated better than he and his family had been in the refugee camps.

"Until I started talking to some people in surrounding communities Rohwer, they thought we were getting treated pretty good ..." he said, explaining that the outside world thought the Japanese Americans in camps were getting better food than everyone else. "After that, I kept my mouth shut."

Both Yada brothers were in the military during the Vietnam War; Richard was deployed after completing an Army Reserve Officers' Training Corps program at UA.

"Things started heating up, so by the time I graduated in '65, it was full-blown," Richard said.

"So, I said, 'I'll go in as an officer and get it over with.'" Richard flew combat missions for the U.S. Air Force in Guam, Thailand, and Okinawa, Japan. His wife, Barbara Yada, had all three of their children while he was on active duty. "I was just barely pregnant when he left, and then he was gone six months and I was pretty far along," she said of their second child.

At the time, Richard said, he had no qualms about joining up; it was just what everyone was supposed to do. But he did have qualms later when he found out about his family members who had died in Hiroshima.

"So, they killed my cousin and tried to kill my grandparents, I guess, and then a few years later, I'm wearing the same uniform," he said

MAKING AMENDS

When Richard and Barbara were putting their kids through college, the apology letters came from President Bill Clinton to all the Japanese Americans who had been imprisoned. Each letter included a check for \$20,000, and "a sincere apology. "It was short and sweet, I guess," Bob said. He bought stocks with his money but ended up taking a loss on the investment.

Barbara said she and Richard used the money to help pay for their children's tuition.

Sam, who kept the greenhouse after his sons had moved out, started efforts to preserve the memory of what happened in Rohwer, **beginning with conserving the memorials internees had built.**

See pictures of the memorials etc. in article # 376

"They're still there," Richard said. "They were made by the people in the camp. They only had scrap material to build them."

Sam started pushing in the 1980s to get a more permanent memorial there, according to fundraising letters he sent out.

These efforts were realized in 1982 when a monument was erected describing what happened. An American flag flies next to the stone marker.

The memorial is in front of a cemetery of about 25 graves of those who died while imprisoned at Rohwer.

"He [Sam] said one of these days these things are going to fall and nobody is going to care," Richard said. "So, he raised money and built a granite monument there behind the two that are there. He said if **the others fall, at least this one will be here so people will remember what this was about.**" The monument is about eight miles from the World War II Japanese American Internment Museum in McGehee, which opened in 2013.

Most of the museum's visitors have used the spot as a pit stop on the way to another location, museum curator Susan Gallion said. Introducing visitors to the museum, Gallion criticizes the government's actions in establishing the camps and chuckles at herself when she does. Although she has lived in the Delta for years, she didn't know about the internment sites until she started working for the museum at its opening. The museum includes art made by internees, personal accounts, and photos. Actor George Takei, who was interned at Rohwer, is scheduled to attend the fifth anniversary of its opening this year, Gallion said. Takei played Hikaru Sulu on *Star Trek*.

Another monument to help people remember what happened is in the works at the site of the Honouliuli Internment Camp, near Waipahu, Hawaii, according to the National Parks Service website. The camp there held about 4,000 people.

The Butler Center for Arkansas Studies has embarked on a two-year journey that describes what happened in Rohwer and Jerome through art and artifacts. Richard attended the opening of the most recent exhibit, the third in the series, on Jan. 12. The exhibit, "Education in Exile: Student Experience at Rohwer Relocation Center," will hang in Concordia Hall until June 30 when the room will be cleared for the fourth and final piece of the series.



Richard Yada, 74, looks over memorabilia that people from around the United States have sent to him at his Little Rock home. Yada was born in a Japanese internment camp in Rohwer while his family was imprisoned there during World War II.



With her husband, Richard Yada, holding the picture frame, Barbara Yada's reflection smiles beside a vintage photo of Richard taken when he was in the U.S. Air Force.



REMEMBERING THE JAPANESE RELOCATION CENTER IN ARKANSAS